

Personal Knowledge Map Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	personal-knowledge-map

Big idea: Knowers inherit knowledge from communities.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A trust colour-code showing automatic trust, earned trust, and contested trust. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Personal Knowledge Map Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A tension line between two sources that disagree about the same claim. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Knowers inherit knowledge from communities.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Personal Knowledge Map Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	To what extent is personal knowledge shaped by knowledge communities?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts.
- A trust colour-code showing automatic trust, earned trust, and contested trust.
- A tension line between two sources that disagree about the same claim.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Activity Steps

1. Students put "my knowledge" in the centre of a page.
2. They add branches: family, school, friends, social media, culture, language, religion, books, experts, algorithms and personal experience.
3. They colour-code sources they trust most, least and automatically.
4. Pairs compare one similarity and one difference.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: To what extent is personal knowledge shaped by knowledge communities?
- Are we responsible for checking inherited beliefs?
- Can a knower ever be fully independent?

Knowledge Questions

- To what extent is personal knowledge shaped by knowledge communities?
- Are we responsible for checking inherited beliefs?
- Can a knower ever be fully independent?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a knowledge map with branches for family, school, language, algorithms, memory, and experts. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...